

STARGAZING BASICS

Southern star hopping

This chart shows you how to star-hop your way around some of the top sights in the southern night sky, visible to people who live in Earth's southern hemisphere. The southern sky gives stargazers a fantastic view of our Milky Way galaxy, as well as celestial wonders such as colourful nebulae, whole galaxies, and the bright constellations Carina, Centaurus, and the Southern Cross.

FINDING THE WAY

- 1 Identify Crux (in red), the Southern Cross (not to be confused with the False Cross) and the Southern Pointer stars Alpha Centauri and Hadar. Draw a line (green) from Hadar to the bottom of the Southern Cross and carry on for the same distance again to reach the famous Carina Nebula.
- 2 Two beautiful star clusters lie close to the Carina Nebula: NGC 3532 and the Southern Pleiades (IC 2602). This second cluster contains five or six naked-eye stars – see how many you can count (you will see more by looking slightly to one side of it). Then use binoculars to view many more.
- 3 Next follow a line (pink) from the top of the Southern Cross, past the Carina Nebula, and onwards by the same distance again. Here you will find the deceptive pattern of the False Cross, and just beyond it the star cluster IC 2391. This impressive jewel box of stars is best appreciated through binoculars.
- 4 Now follow (purple) the downward (longer) bar of the Southern Cross and cross an empty area of the sky to reach the Small Magellanic Cloud. This small galaxy orbits our own Milky Way galaxy and contains hundreds of millions of stars. Nearby is an impressive globular cluster of stars known as 47 Tucanae.
- 5 Finally, return to the Southern Pointers and follow a line (orange) from Alpha Centauri to discover three bright stars that form a triangle shape – named constellation Triangulum Australe.



The False Cross mimics the shape of the true Southern Cross, but is slightly fainter.